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The Fast Rise, Long Decline, and Agonizing Downfall of the MTV Empire

The audience for music videos is bigger than ever — even as
the flagship music video network keeps killing itself off

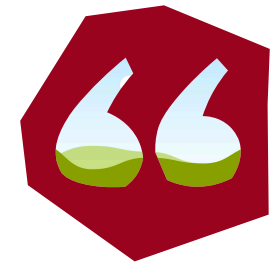
By Rob Sheffield
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All the reports about the death of music videos have been wildly exaggerated. But that's only fair, since wild exaggerations are exactly what music videos are all about. These days MTV and CMT might be going down in flames, but nobody can kill the dream of music videos. Why? They're the best starmaking machinery the pop world has ever invented, the ultimate expression of rock-star fantasy, outliving all the countless predictions of their demise over the years. As one of the all-time great MTV stars once asked: Isn't it ironic? Doncha think?

MTV debuted on August 1, 1981, which means it was probably August 2 when people started complaining MTV didn't play music anymore. But really, MTV doesn't play music anymore, and that's nothing new. Fans still devour videos, just as artists still love making them. They remain a phenomenally popular concept. As Lady Gaga said in 2010, when she dominated the VMAs, "God put me on Earth for three reasons: to make loud music, gay videos, and cause a damn ruckus." Fifteen years later, Gaga is still making gay videos and still causing a ruckus. But MTV would rather just be excluded from this narrative.

The network just made headlines around the world when it announced it's killing off its music channels in the U.K. and Europe. But meanwhile, back in the U.S.A., MTV keeps on doing what it's been doing for years, which is cranking Catfish and Ridiculousness reruns. Even though MTV just pulled the plug on Ridiculousness after a mind-boggling 46 seasons, they've got enough episodes stockpiled to run forever. Jersey Shore: Family Vacation is still in production, eight seasons and counting—longer than the original version — with no escape in sight for these poor guido hostages; it's the Hotel California of GTL.

MTV Classic still programs music around the clock, in oldies blocks like I Want My Eighties, Nineties Nation, Yo! Hip Hip Mix, Total Request Playlist, or Metal Mayhem. MTVU and MTV Live have new music, MTV2 sticks to sitcom reruns, and VH1 makes sure nobody has to lie awake at night and wonder whatever happened to Nick Cannon Presents Wild N' Out.



Our audience grew up with us until the videos, and they were beginning to get a little long in the tooth.



- Dusty Hill, bassist for ZZ Top